

Justices skeptical of ban on ‘therapy’

State laws barring ‘conversion’ counsel for gay, trans youths are before high court.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court justices on Tuesday heard a free-speech challenge to state laws against “conversion therapy” and sounded likely to rule the measures violate the 1st Amendment.

California and more than 20 other states have adopted laws to forbid licensed counselors from urging or encouraging gay or transgender teens to change their sexual orientation or gender identity.

The laws were adopted in reaction to a history of dangerous and discredited practices, including treatments that induced nausea and vomiting or administered electric shocks.

Lawmakers and medical experts said such efforts to “cure” LGBTQ+ teens were cruel and ineffective and caused lasting harm. But these “talk therapy” laws have been challenged by a number of Christian counselors who believe they can help young people who want to talk about their feelings and their sexual identity.

The court on Tuesday heard an appeal from Kaley Chiles, a counselor from Colorado Springs, Colo. She says she is an evangelical Christian but does not seek to “cure” young people of a same-sex attraction or change their gender identity.

She sued, alleging the state law seeks to “censor” her conversations and threatens her with punishment.

She lost before a federal judge and a U.S. appeals court, both of whom said the state has the authority to regulate the practice of medicine and to prevent substandard healthcare.

But the Supreme Court voted to hear her appeal.

“This law bans voluntary conversations, censoring widely held views on debated moral, religious and scientific questions,” her attorney James Campbell said in his opening.

The justices, both conservative and liberal, appeared to agree the Colorado law violated the 1st Amendment guarantee of free speech.

“What’s being regulated here is pure speech,” said [See Court, A6]



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CHRIS McGRATH Getty Images

IN REIM, Israel, visitors pay tribute Tuesday to those killed or abducted from the Nova music festival as part of the Hamas-led attack on Oct. 7, 2023. Israel responded with a deadly military campaign that has destroyed much of Gaza, top.

Two years later, worlds shattered in Israel, Gaza

Hamas’ Oct. 7 attack destroyed lives, sense of security; war has left enclave in ruins.

By NABIH BULOS

BEERI, Israel — Little has changed in the house of Miri Gad Messika’s parents from two years ago, when Hamas-led militants blitzed into this tiny community less than three miles from Gaza’s eastern edge, killing more than 100 people and kidnapping 32 others.

The scorch marks from the fighting that day still mar the walls, and the underbrush of bullet-shattered tiles crackles with Messika’s every step. To the side lay a stuffed panda doll, dusty and discarded on what remained of a kitchen counter.

“We always used to say this place is 99% heaven and 1% hell,” Messika said, her eyes sweeping across the room before looking out into the ravaged courtyard.

The heaven part was the place she knew all her life as a third-generation resident of Beeri, with its printing press and basketball team. Hell? That was the periodic rocket attacks during the

decades of flare-ups between the militant group Hamas and Israel that would send residents racing into their safe rooms.

“But we knew how to manage that,” she said. “We just went into the safe room and closed the door. That’s it.”

But 10 minutes into the onslaught that fateful Saturday morning on Oct. 7, 2023, Messika understood it was “a historic event.”

“We weren’t prepared for such a thing,” she said.

On Tuesday, the second anniversary of the attack, Messika and others across Israel recalled the day that sparked the country’s longest war, shattered Israelis’ long-held sense of security and entrenched anew the hatreds and divisions long a part of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. The scars endure like the lingering smell of soot in her parents’ home.

Four Beeri residents remain in Hamas’ hands, but none are alive, Messika said, adding to a tally of 102 people who were killed — almost 10% of the kibbutz’s population. And while a few hundred residents have returned to live here, most remain in alternative housing, awaiting a reconstruction project to repair the I34 [See Oct. 7, A4]

MONO LAKE’S EQUINE ISSUE

Wild horses are trampling the otherworldly landscape. Federal agencies plan a roundup, but tribes and others seek an alternative.

By LILA SEIDMAN

Several dozen horses calmly graze along the shores of Mono Lake, a sparkling saline expanse spread out before the jagged Sierra Nevada. The September sun is blazing. A pair of brown horses come up side by side and stare intensely at an approaching visitor.

These wild equines soon may disappear from beside the ancient lake. The prospect is stirring emotional disagreement over the future of the herd, which has surged to more than three times what federal officials say the land can support.

“These horses deserve a place to roam and be free, but around Mono Lake is not the place,” said Bartshe Miller of the Mono Lake Committee, an environmental nonprofit.

This year, the U.S. Forest Service and Bureau of Land Management approved a plan to round up [See Horses, A14]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

WILD HORSES graze along the eastern shores of Mono Lake, famed for limestone columns called tufa. Hundreds could be rounded up.

COUNTY OPENS INQUIRY OF ABUSE PAYOUT

Report that plaintiffs were paid to sue leads to scrutiny of \$4-billion settlement.

By REBECCA ELLIS

Los Angeles County launched an investigation Tuesday to determine whether a record \$4-billion sex abuse settlement approved this year may be tainted.

County supervisors unanimously approved a motion to have county lawyers investigate possible misconduct by “legal representatives” involved in the recent flood of sex abuse litigation against L.A. County. The county auditor’s office also will set up a hotline dedicated to tips from the public related to the lawsuits, according to the motion.

“It is appalling and sickening that anyone would exploit a system meant to bring justice to victims of childhood sexual abuse,” said Supervisor Kathryn Barger, who first called for the investigation. “We must ensure that nothing like this ever happens again and that every penny that we are allocating to victims goes directly to the survivors.”

Barger said she was “incredibly disturbed and quite frankly disturbed” by a Times investigation published last week that found seven plaintiffs in the largest sex abuse settlement in U.S. history who claimed they were paid by recruiters to sue the county. Two people said they were told to make up claims of abuse. The plaintiffs who spoke with The Times said the recruiters paid them outside a social services office in South Los Angeles.

All of the people who said they were paid by the recruiters were represented by Downtown L.A. Law Group, or DTLA, a personal injury firm with more than 2,700 plaintiffs in the settlement. DTLA has denied any [See Abuse, A8]

Teen’s death stops D4vd’s meteoric rise as fans hunt for clues

By RICHARD WINTON, NATHAN SOLIS AND AUGUST BROWN

One of David Anthony Burke’s first songs was called “Romantic Homicide.”

The teenager was just starting to use a phone app called BandLab to write music for the gaming videos he posted online.

“In the back of my mind, I killed you, and I didn’t even regret it ... I hate you,” he sang.

After Burke became D4vd and his fame exploded as a fresh voice for Gen Z, he appeared in a music video elaborating on the murderous theme. Knives spill from a suitcase. A young woman with an apparent chest wound lies on a bed as he hovers over her blindfolded, his white shirt spattered with blood.

Now, D4vd’s fans, along with many who hadn’t previously heard of him, are dis-

secting his DIY songs about twisted romance for clues, after the badly decomposed body of a 15-year-old girl was found in the trunk of a Tesla he owned.

In the video for another song, “One More Dance,” D4vd drags a person — who also appears to be him — to a car, where a couple stuffs him into the trunk.

Los Angeles police detectives have said that the singer, 20, is cooperating with their investigation. They are seeking to understand any connections between him and the girl, Celeste Rivas Hernandez, with livestreams and videos appearing to show the two together. No one has been charged in connection with Celeste’s death.

D4vd’s rise from a home-schooled Houston teenager posting Fortnite videos online to a burgeoning pop star with a multimillion-dollar recording contract was singular. In an interview with [See D4vd, A8]

Bondi combative with lawmakers

Attorney general dodges Democrats’ questions during a Senate hearing. **NATION, A5**



WIN MCNAMEE Getty Images
Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi

L.A. trash fees poised to surge

Single-family homes and others soon will pay almost \$56 a month. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

‘Wheel’ defense carries Dodgers

Unique play to defend bunt preserves lead in ninth, Bill Shaikin writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather

Clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 76/57. **B6**

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One-two punch of massive quakes

Study suggests one fault often triggered another in California and could do so again.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

They are two of the West Coast’s most destructive generators of huge earthquakes: the San Andreas fault in California and the Cascadia subduction zone offshore of California’s North Coast, Oregon, Washington and British Columbia.

The public has often thought of these danger zones as separate entities.

But what if they were capable of back-to-back disasters?

That’s the unsettling possibility described in a groundbreaking study published recently in the journal *Geosphere*.

The authors suggest that, for thousands of years, large earthquakes on the Cascadia subduction zone were quickly followed by

large earthquakes on the northern San Andreas fault.

In 1700, a Cascadia subduction zone earthquake is believed to have measured around a magnitude 9. Based on archaeological evidence, villages sank and had to be abandoned, according to the U.S. Geological Survey. That earthquake was so powerful, entire sections of the Pacific coastline dropped by as much as 5 feet. In the Pacific Northwest, Native American stories told of “how the prairie became ocean” and canoes were flung into trees.

The study suggests the Cascadia earthquake was followed by a northern San Andreas fault earthquake from Cape Mendocino toward San Francisco, with a magnitude of around 7.9.

“What that suggests is that the San Andreas earthquake happened very closely in time after the Cascadia earthquake,” said Jason R. Patton, engineering geologist with the California Geological Survey and a co-author of the study. [See Earthquake, A7]